Klarna: Which Markets Come After the Nordics

Updated: 2026-10-26.

BONUS CASE · GOES WITH MODULE 12 · GOAL M12-LG1

Bonus case for Module 12, Fundraising & Demo Day, of Ambitious Entrepreneurship. Prepared by Bastian Burger from public sources. The case does not judge whether any decision was right or wrong. Licensed under CC BY-NC-SA 4.0 except third-party material as marked.

In July 2009, Sebastian Siemiatkowski, 27, chief executive and co-founder of the Stockholm company Kreditor, had to decide which countries outside the Nordics the company would enter next.[1] Kreditor let people shop online and pay by invoice after delivery. On 29 June it had announced that it would change its name to Klarna in the autumn.[2] Klarna's own history later explained that "a new name is needed that can be marketed outside the Nordic countries".[3] The sources do not date the decision about the next countries.

Sweden and the Nordics

Three students at the Stockholm School of Economics, Siemiatkowski, Victor Jacobsson and Niklas Adalberth, started Kreditor in 2005. Shops that connected to it could offer payment after delivery. Siemiatkowski explained in 2009 that shops needed their money at once and that Kreditor stepped in as the intermediary.[1] According to the company, Kreditor opened its payment solution to consumers in Norway, Denmark and Finland in 2008.[3] Siemiatkowski recalled in 2024 that the first markets after Sweden, which he named as Norway and Finland, were "partially driven by merchant demand", because "a lot of Swedish ecommerce merchants were active" there.[4]

In July 2009, Dagens Nyheter reported that Kreditor had about 4,000 online shops connected, more than one million consumers using it and about 120 employees. Its annualised revenue was about SEK 200 million. It handled payments of SEK 2 billion to 3 billion a year and the newspaper reported that Kreditor had been profitable since it began in 2005.[1] The Swedish financial regulator had recently authorised Kreditor as a credit market company, which, the newspaper wrote, gave it room to broaden its business, among other things by taking deposits from customers.[1] The press release on the new name called it part of a brand strategy to raise sales for the 4,000 connected shops, and it said that more than 1.2 million consumers had paid through one of Kreditor's two solutions, invoice or instalments.[2]

Markets beyond the Nordics

Siemiatkowski described the choice in 2024 in terms of how people paid. In Germany and the Netherlands there was "a strong tradition of what in Germany is referred to as Rechnung, which is basically invoice or buy-now-pay-later". In the United States and the United Kingdom, he said, "credit cards are so prevalent".[4] The four markets he named differed greatly in size (Exhibit 1).[5]

By July 2009 Kreditor served four Nordic markets, was profitable and had announced a name it could market outside the Nordics. Siemiatkowski had to decide which countries to enter first, those where people already paid on invoice or those where most paid by card.

Exhibit 1: Klarna’s Nordic markets and four other markets, 2008

Market	Status in July 2009	Population, millions	Internet users per 100 people
Sweden	Home market, since 2005	9.2	90
Norway	Opened to consumers in 2008, according to the company	4.8	91
Denmark	Opened to consumers in 2008, according to the company	5.5	85
Finland	Opened to consumers in 2008, according to the company	5.3	84
Germany	Named by Siemiatkowski in 2024	82.1	78
Netherlands	Named by Siemiatkowski in 2024	16.4	87
United Kingdom	Named by Siemiatkowski in 2024	61.8	78
United States	Named by Siemiatkowski in 2024	304.1	74

Source: World Bank, World Development Indicators, series SP.POP.TOTL and IT.NET.USER.ZS, values for 2008 as published in October 2026, see note 5. The status column follows notes 3 and 4. The World Bank revises its series, so the figures may differ from those published in 2009.

Endnotes

1. “Finansbolaget som expanderar mitt i krisen” (The finance company that expands in the middle of the crisis), Dagens Nyheter, 21 July 2009 (stamp “Publicerat 2009-07-21 00:29”), Internet Archive capture of 24 July 2009, https://web.archive.org/web/20090724081558/http://www.dn.se/ekonomi/finansbolaget-som-expanderar-mitt-i-krisen-1.915220, accessed 2026-10-26. By Johan Schück. Summarised from Swedish by the case writer. Dating of the case. The sources do not date the decision about which countries to enter next. The case writer set it in July 2009, the month after the name change announced on 29 June 2009. The 2009 release gave brand and sales reasons for the name. The company’s 2012 history tied it to marketing outside the Nordic countries (note 3).
2. Kreditor, “Kreditor byter namn till Klarna” (Kreditor changes its name to Klarna), press release, 29 June 2009 (date as listed on Klarna’s press page), Internet Archive capture of 12 March 2010, https://web.archive.org/web/20100312072137/http://klarna.com/sv/press/151-kreditor-byter-namn-till-klarna, accessed 2026-10-26. Summarised from Swedish by the case writer.
3. Klarna, “Our journey”, klarna.com/en/about-us/history, Internet Archive capture of 28 March 2012, https://web.archive.org/web/20120328124846/https://klarna.com/en/about-us/history, accessed 2026-10-26. Written by the company, three years after the events it dates to 2008 and 2009.
4. Sebastian Siemiatkowski, interviewed in “Building a Disruptive Payments Company (with Klarna CEO Sebastian Siemiatkowski)”, Acquired (ACQ2 series, podcast), 24 June 2024, published transcript, https://www.acquired.fm/acq2-episodes/building-a-disruptive-payments-company-with-klarna-ceo-sebastian-siemiatkowski, accessed 2026-10-26. Quotes are from the show’s transcript and were not checked against the audio. Siemiatkowski’s account is a recollection, told 15 years after the events.
5. World Bank, World Development Indicators, SP.POP.TOTL and IT.NET.USER.ZS for Sweden, Norway, Denmark, Finland, Germany, the Netherlands, the United Kingdom and the United States, API data last updated 2026-10-08, https://api.worldbank.org/v2/country/SWE;NOR;DNK;FIN;DEU;NLD;GBR;USA/indicator/SP.POP.TOTL?format=json&date=2008, accessed 2026-10-26. The same URL pattern serves the other series.